Puzzle Drill Booklet

A friendly getting-started guide

Tactics decide most club games, and tactics grow from reps. This booklet is the paper trail for those reps: six original starter drills to learn the rhythm, blank drill pages for the puzzles in your own book or course, a running log of every session, and an answer key for the starters — kept honest, at the end, where you agreed not to peek.

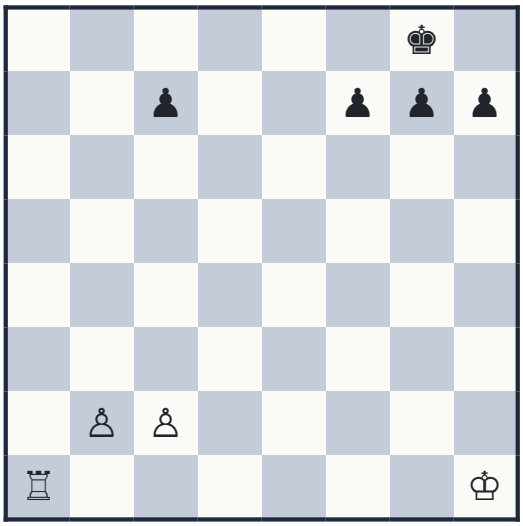
How to use it

1. **Do the six starters first.** They are all "White to move, mate in one" — same skill, six shapes. Solve on the diagram, write the move in the slot *before* consulting the key.
2. **Then bring in your own puzzles.** From any book, course, or app: set the position up on a blank drill page (that little sketch grid doubles as visualization practice), record your move, your time, and whether you nailed it.
3. **Log every session** on the log page. The honest columns — solved vs. hinted — matter more than speed early on.
4. **Cover the answer key** (last page if you folded this booklet) until the moment of checking. No peeking spoils all six starters at once.
5. **Missed one?** That's the good one. Re-solve it tomorrow before starting new material.

Pencils only. You will be tempted by faint, wrong, wonderful ideas — and you will want to erase them. That is the whole method: try boldly in pencil, correct cleanly, keep moving.

Beginner tip: Don't rush the starters. Mate in one is a *pattern* exercise: first see the checks, then see the mates, then the quiet moves that only look safe.

Starter drills — White to move, mate in one

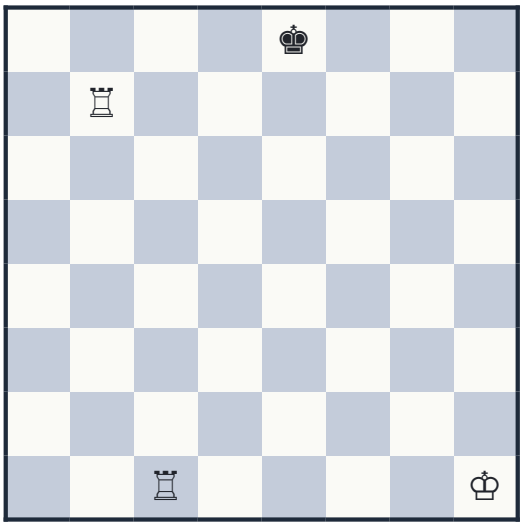


Drill 1 — back ranks, the classic shape

FEN: `6k1/2p2ppp/8/8/8/8/1PP5/R6K`

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint ☐ missed it

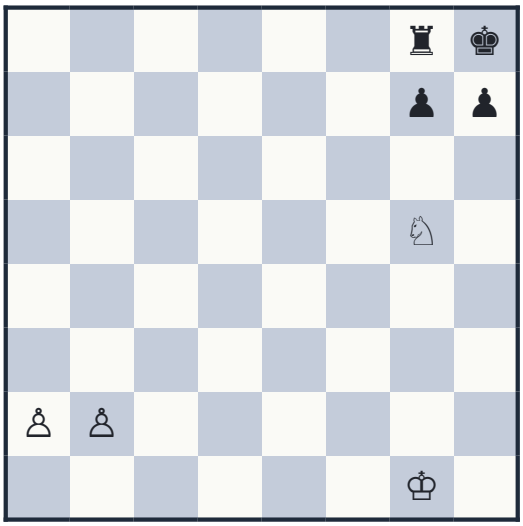


Drill 2 — two rooks, the ladder's last rung

FEN: `4k3/1R6/8/8/8/8/8/2R4K`

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint ☐ missed it



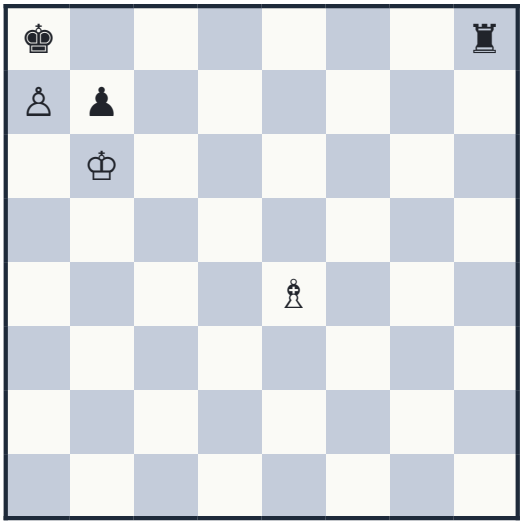
Drill 3 — the knight that boxes a king in

FEN: `6rk/6pp/8/6N1/8/8/PP6/6K1`

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint ☐ missed it

Pencils only — no pens near the board. Three more starters overleaf.

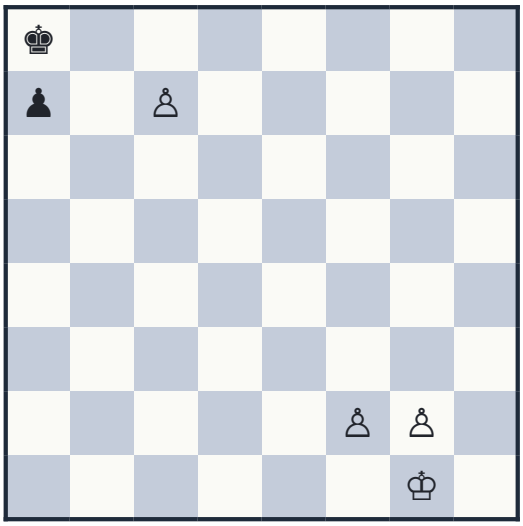


Drill 4 — capture into the corner

FEN: `k6r/Pp6/1K6/8/4B3/8/8/8`

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint ☐ missed it

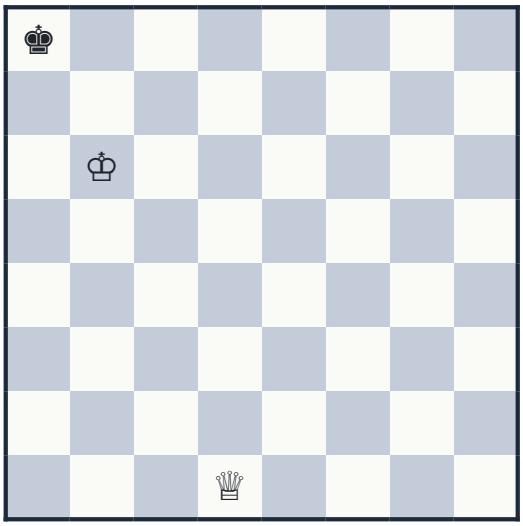


Drill 5 — the pawn's last step

FEN: `k7/p1P5/8/8/8/8/5PP1/6K1`

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint ☐ missed it



Drill 6 — the every-endgame finish

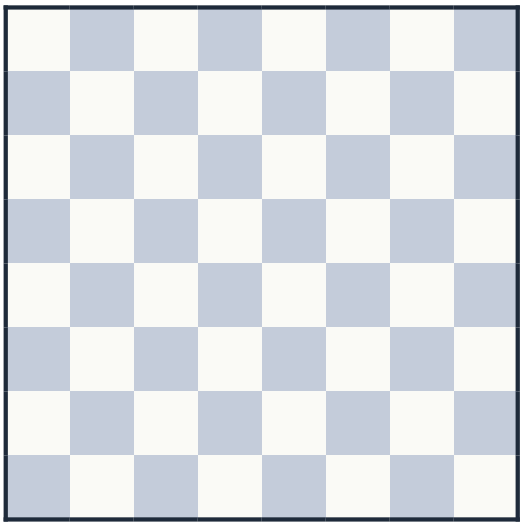
FEN: `k7/8/1K6/8/8/8/8/3Q4`

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint ☐ missed it

Pencils only — no pens near the board. Answer key at the end of the booklet.

Drill pages (bring your own puzzles)

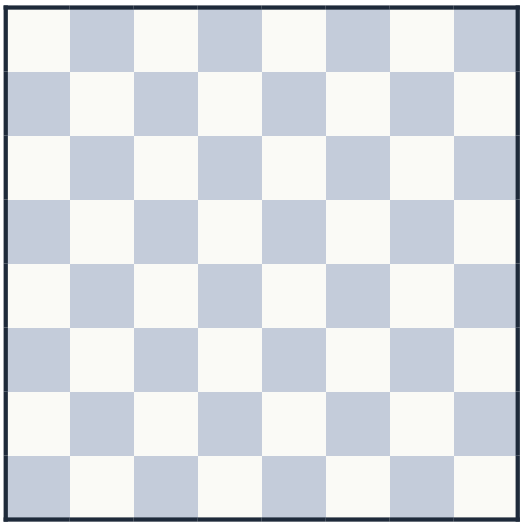


Sketch the position here:

Source (book / course / page): _____

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint
☐ missed it — redo date: _____



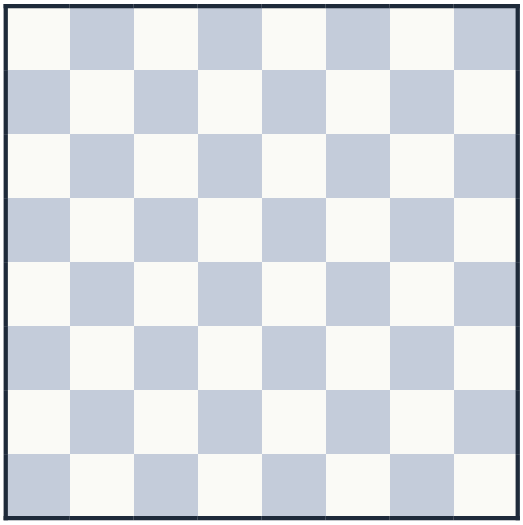
Sketch the position here:

Source (book / course / page): _____

My solution: _____

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint
☐ missed it — redo date: _____

Pencils only — no pens near the board. Two more blank drill pages overleaf; photocopy or print extras to grow the booklet.

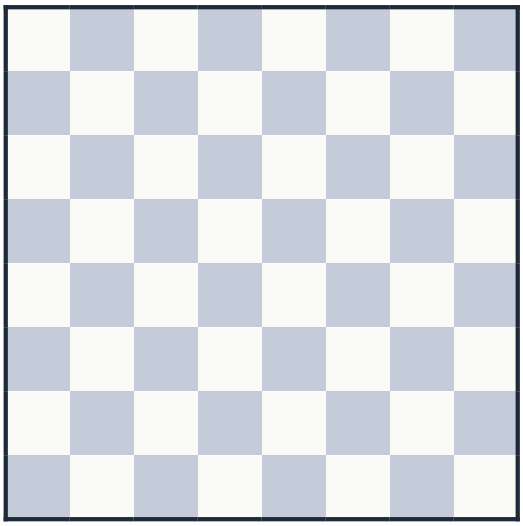


Sketch the position here:

Source (book / course / page):

My solution:

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint
☐ missed it — redo date: _____



Sketch the position here:

Source (book / course / page):

My solution:

☐ nailed it ☐ needed a hint
☐ missed it — redo date: _____

Pencils only — no pens near the board. Sketching positions from memory builds board vision faster than reading does.

Drill log

Time control I'm training for: _____ **Book / course in use:** _____

DATE	WHAT I DRILLED	DONE	HINTS	TIME ON	ONE LINE ABOUT THE PATTERN

Pencils only — no pens near the board. "Hints" is the honest column; three hinted misses on one theme = your next lesson.

Answer key — starter drills

If you are reading this before writing something down, close the booklet, breathe, and try the six first. The key is for after.

DRILL	KEY MOVE	WHY IT WORKS
1	**Ra8#**	The rook slides down the open a-file to the last rank. Black's own pawn wall (f7-g7-h7) blocks every escape.
2	**Rc8#**	Ladder finish: the b7 rook guards the 7th rank, the c1 rook lands on the 8th. Escape squares come in pairs — cover them both.
3	**Nf7#**	The knight lands on f7 and the black king is boxed in entirely by its own rook and pawns — a first taste of the smothered mate.
4	**Bxb7#**	Capture into the corner: the bishop checks from b7, the white king on b6 guards *the bishop itself*, and the a7 pawn seals the b8 escape. A guarding king turns a bold capture into mate.
5	**c8=Q#**	Promote and mate in one: the new queen checks along the 8th while the a7 black pawn, the queen itself, and capture-safety take care of every king square. (Rook also mates — spotting that earns bonus points.)
6	**Qd8#**	The queen slides to the 8th rank and the white king on b7's doorstep (b6) seals the a7 and b7 escapes. This is how every won queen-and-king ending should finish.

Pencils only — no pens near the board. Each starter has exactly one mating move — if you found something else that looked like mate, check the escape squares again: that hunt is the actual lesson. Starter positions in this booklet were composed for it, and every one is verified by the pack's tests.